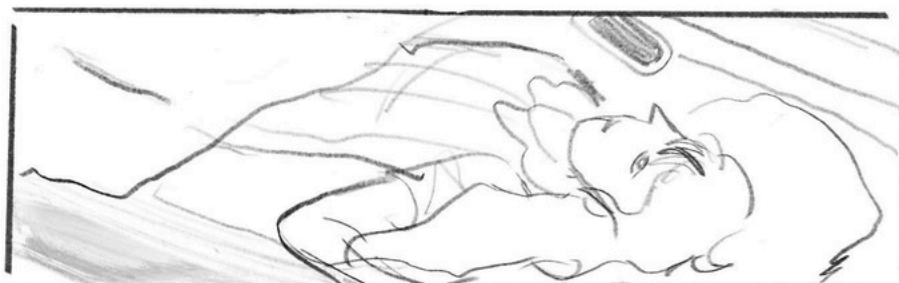




Why are you so scared of the ocean if you've never even drowned before?



Maybe some fears are inherited. Maybe someone once described drowning too well.



I think about the way people hold their breath before crossing the street. The small, invisible ritual of it. They probably don't even notice they're doing it.



Shoulders tighten, lungs pause, heartbeat folds on itself for the few seconds between one curb and the next. Like a superstition inherited from bodies that used to live near danger



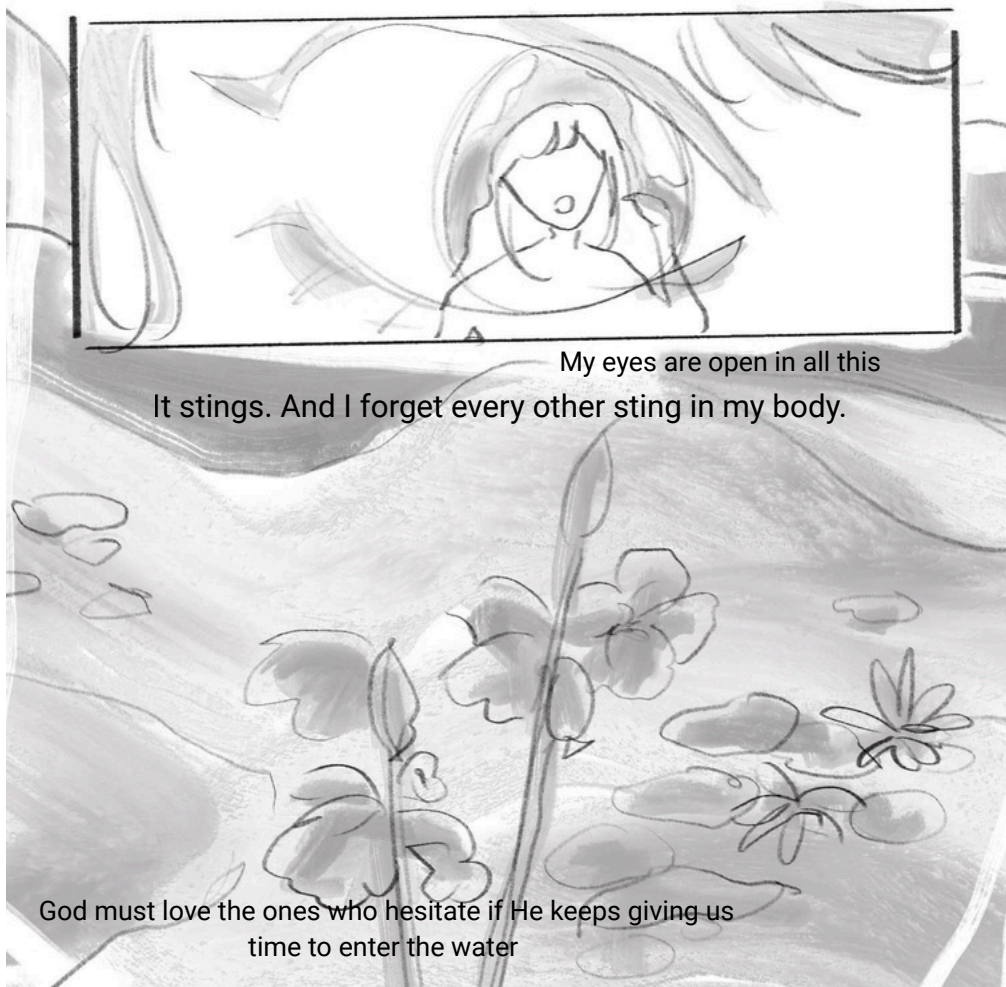
Maybe it's all I've been doing. Holding my breath before an imaginary impact.



Every generation learns a different version of drowning. My grandmother calls it patience. My mother, caution. I call it standing still and hoping the air will forgive me for taking up space in it.



I've never drowned, but I've rehearsed it enough times that my body already knows the choreography.



My eyes are open in all this
It stings. And I forget every other sting in my body.

God must love the ones who hesitate if He keeps giving us
time to enter the water